principles. Having sent the resignation letter, Ratan went home a less burdened man, picked up his dog and set off for Juhu. He reminisces that it was ‘probably the best day of my life, completely free of everything’.

JRD had obviously not been prepared for such a reaction. When he returned home, JRD’s driver was waiting for him. He told him, ‘*Saab bula rahe hai* (Sir is asking for you).’

Instead of going with the driver right away, Ratan telephoned JRD, who asked him: ‘What are you doing?’ Ratan replied: ‘Jeh, I’m not giving you an ultimatum, I’ve done it.’ He had already resigned, and he added that they would remain the ‘best of friends’, irrespective of what ensued.

Ratan recalls, ‘He [JRD] asked me to come there and I went to his house. There was a letter from Russi Mody.’ He had written: ‘I hadn’t realized how passionate or how important Moolgaokar was to you. I would withdraw my pressure, please don’t resign, etc.’ JRD also advised Ratan to reconsider his decision. Deferring to him, and on the back of the assurance given by Mody in his letter, Ratan withdrew his resignation.

Ratan’s equation with Moolgaokar had taken a number of twists and turns up until that point. When Ratan had returned from his short stint in Australia in 1970, he was asked by Moolgaokar to go back to Jamshedpur. Ratan refused, and he was, as he says, ‘denounced for it, if you might’. Moolgaokar didn’t speak to him for eight or nine years. ‘Then one day, the sun shone and he became my best friend and my highest benefactor over a computer company that we invested in the US and then, to the day he died, Moolgaokar was … very nice to me, though he was never really close and friendly with anybody. And all through the short period of time that I was in TELCO while he was alive, it was a pleasure to be with him,’ Ratan explains.

An enraged Moolgaokar continued his efforts to prevent Mody from succeeding him. He had already persuaded Ratan to take over as deputy chairman. His next aim was to see Ratan appointed as the TELCO chairman. And to make things difficult for Mody, he heaped praise on Ratan in a communication to the shareholders on 29 June, saying: ‘He has had top-level exposure to a number of companies, several of which he has strategically directed towards businesses in high-technology industries. As such, he is well equipped to help TELCO chart its course in the coming years … I believe he will be the correct choice for succeeding me as the chairman of TELCO.’